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Matthijs Holter's
HEXCRAWL
ENCOUNTER
DESIGN
GUIDEBOOK

HEXCRAWL

ENCOUNTER DESIGN GUIDEBOOK

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FOREWORD

In the Hexcrawl Guidebook, I gave you the structure: maps, turns, procedures. This book is about what happens inside that structure.

I spent years running hexcrawls where the encounter design came last and got the least attention. I'd spend an evening drawing a gorgeous map, then fill the encounter tables in twenty minutes with wolves and bandits. The sessions worked, but they didn't stick. The moment I started investing real craft into encounters, everything changed.

I wrote this book as a companion to the first. I assume you already understand hex maps, keyed locations, exploration turns, and random encounter procedures. If those terms are unfamiliar, start with the Hexcrawl Guidebook. Everything here builds on that foundation.

What I cover here is how to design encounters that do real work: encounters that reveal the world, force decisions, and connect to each other across sessions. I show you how to build tables that stay fresh across sessions, how to make terrain feel alive, and how to pace your sessions so the wilderness stays compelling. These are the techniques that separate a merely functional hexcrawl from one your players talk about for years.

I'm still opinionated. I tell you what works, what fails, and why. Where the community disagrees, I pick a side and explain my reasoning. You're free to disagree, but you'll know exactly what you're disagreeing with.

- Matthijs

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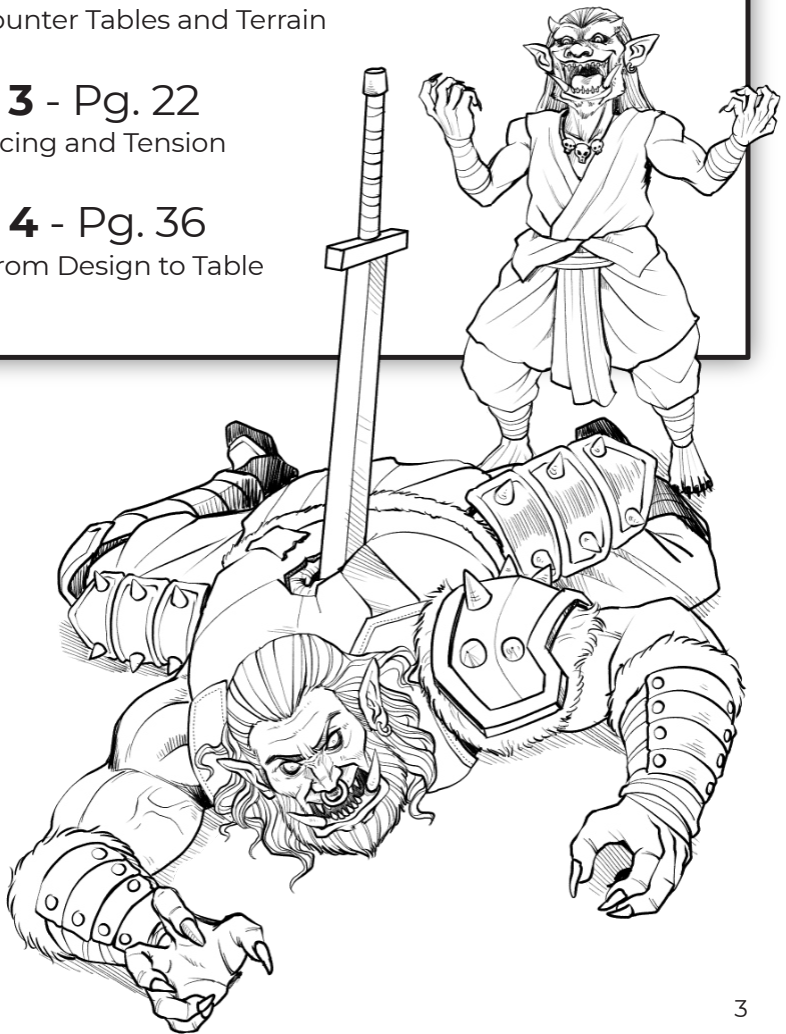
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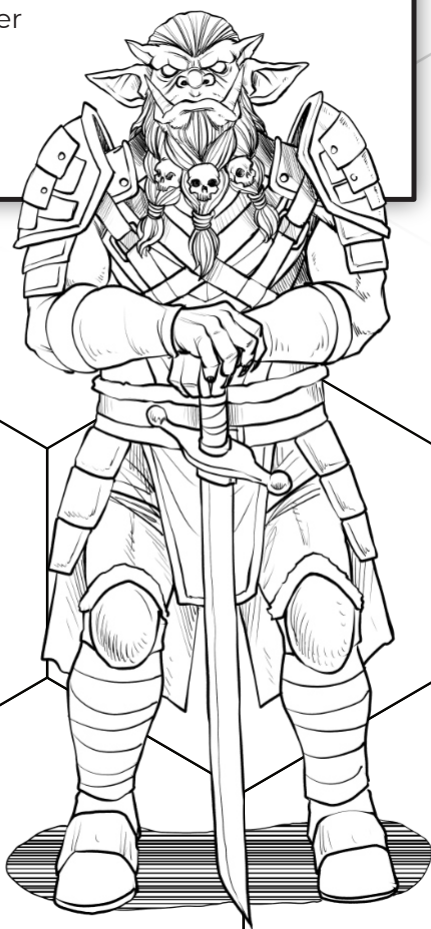
INTRODUCTION

This book is about how to fill your hexes with life. I wrote it because encounters are where your hexcrawl comes alive or falls flat, and most GMs underinvest in them.

You'll learn:

1. Why encounters deserve more prep time than cartography
2. The encounter trifecta for evaluating every encounter you write

This book is written for the Game Master (GM), the person who builds the map, stocks it with content, and runs the game.



Why Encounters Matter More Than Maps

The hex map gives you a way to structure travel. It tells players where they can go, how long travel takes, and what terrain stands between them and their goal. But a well-built map doesn't guarantee memorable sessions. If the map is the skeleton, I believe encounters are the muscles that make it move.

A perfect map with dull encounters makes for dull sessions. Players cross forests, wade across rivers, reach the marked location, fight the marked creature, collect the marked treasure. Everything works. Nothing surprises.

A rough map with vivid encounters produces sessions that stick. The burning caravan, the griffon that landed ten feet away and just watched them, the ruin occupied by someone who knew their name. These moments are what players mean when they say the wilderness felt real.

The procedure keeps the game moving. Encounters give it somewhere worth moving toward. They are the reason players lean over the table and ask “*what do we see?*” instead of “*how many hexes until we get there?*”

I recommend treating encounter design as more important than map design. Many GMs disagree, and the map-first approach is the default advice in most hexcrawl guides. I've tried both. The sessions where I spent my prep budget on encounters consistently outperformed the sessions where I spent it on maps. A hex map takes an evening to draw. The encounters inside it take a campaign to get right, and that's where this book focuses.

Failure mode: The GM who spends twenty hours on cartography and twenty minutes on encounters. The map looks gorgeous. The sessions feel hollow.

Summary:

- *The hex map creates structure. Encounters create experience*
- *Rough maps with vivid encounters outperform polished maps with bland ones*
- *Encounter design deserves more prep time than cartography*

The Encounter Trifecta

Every wilderness encounter should do at least one of three things: force a decision, reveal the world, or drain and reward resources. If an encounter does none of these, cut it. It is consuming table time without earning it.

Force a decision. The encounter presents the party with a choice that has no obvious correct answer. Fight the ogre or sneak past. Help the stranded pilgrim or keep moving before dark. Follow the smoke column or avoid whatever caused it. Decisions make players active. Without them, the wilderness becomes a sequence of things that happen to the party rather than a space the party navigates through judgment and intent.

Reveal the world. The encounter teaches the players something about the setting they did not know before. The abandoned watchtower shows how far the kingdom's borders have retreated. The dead elk with crystalline growths on its antlers signals that the corruption from Hex 15 is spreading. Revelation makes travel feel like exploration rather than commuting. Each hex crossed adds to the party's understanding of where they are.

Drain or reward resources. The encounter costs something (hit points, spell slots, rations, torches, time) or provides something (gold, information, a safe rest, a shortcut). Resource pressure is what makes hexcrawl decisions count. Without it, every choice is cosmetic. With it, helping the pilgrim costs a day of rations and gains a blessing. Avoiding the ogre saves hit points but loses the treasure it guards.

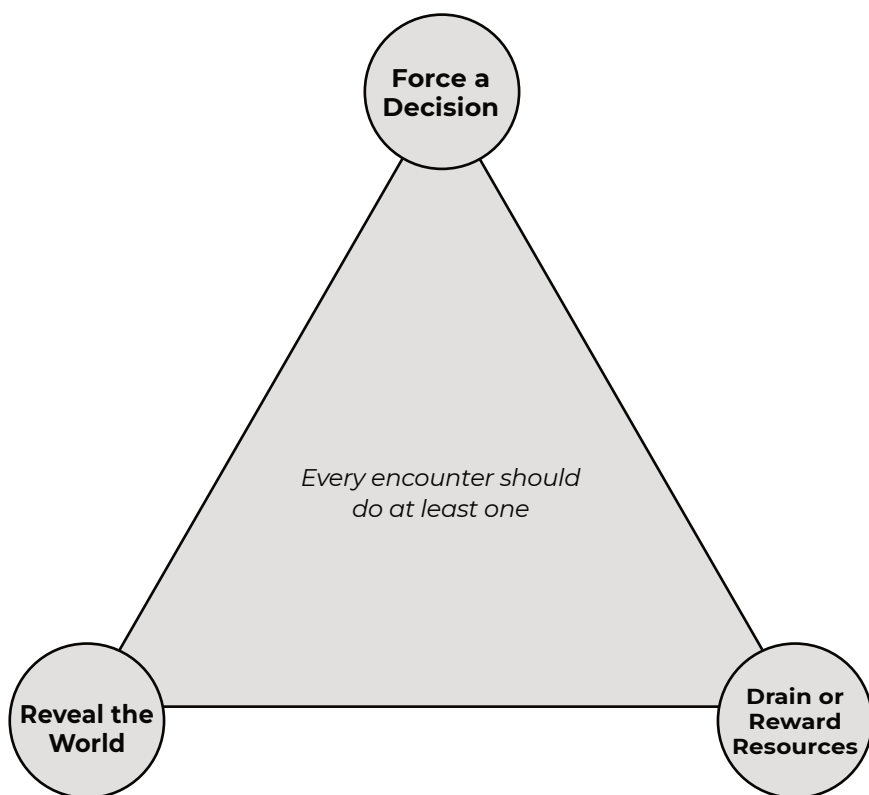
I recommend checking every encounter you write against the trifecta. Many strong encounters do two. The best do all three. An encounter that does zero is filler, and filler in a hexcrawl is more damaging than in a dungeon because travel already risks feeling slow.

Failure mode: An encounter that does none of the three. “*2d6 wolves attack*” creates no decision (fight is the only option), reveals nothing about the world, and drains hit points without meaningful trade-offs. It consumes table time and gives nothing back.

Summary:

- *The encounter trifecta: force a decision, reveal the world, drain or reward resources*
- *Encounters doing zero jobs are filler and should be cut*
- *The best encounters hit two or three simultaneously*
- *The encounter trifecta: a triangle with Force a Decision, Reveal the World, and Drain or Reward Resources at each corner*

Try this now: Pull out your last session's encounter list and count how many entries were just combat.



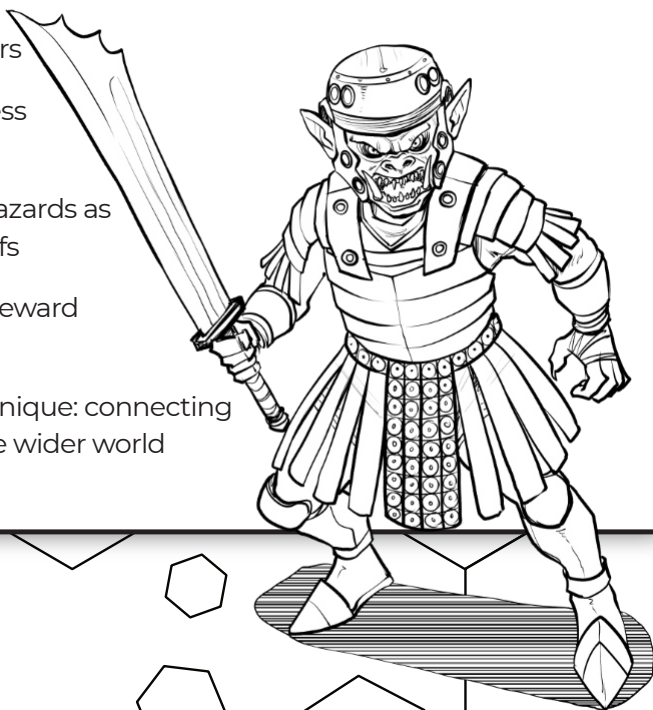
CHAPTER 1

ENCOUNTER BUILDING BLOCKS

Encounter tables should be more than monster lists. In this chapter, I show you how to make them work harder. I break down the specific encounter types that make wilderness travel interesting, show you the ratios that keep tables balanced, and give you techniques for encounters that connect to each other across sessions.

You'll learn:

1. The 60/40 rule for balancing encounter types
2. Signs and traces as tension-builders
3. NPCs as wilderness encounters
4. Environmental hazards as resource trade-offs
5. Discoveries that reward exploration
6. The layering technique: connecting encounters to the wider world



1. The 60/40 Rule

A hexcrawl encounter table with eight entries should have at least five non-combat results. That's the 60/40 rule: sixty percent of your table entries create situations that don't start with initiative rolls.

The reasoning is structural. The exploration turn already generates attrition through travel itself. Every watch (a six-hour block of travel) costs rations. Navigation failures cost time. Bad weather costs daylight. Combat on top of that, every time the dice come up “encounter,” turns travel into a war of hit point erosion. Players stop exploring and start conserving, which kills the forward momentum hexcrawl depends on. The encounter table should be pulling its weight in different ways: forcing decisions, revealing the world, creating social and environmental pressure. Combat is one of its tools, not its default.

Your non-combat sixty percent draws from four categories, each covered in detail in the sections that follow:

1. **Signs and traces** are evidence that something is nearby without that something being present. They create tension and put a choice in front of the party: follow or ignore?
2. **NPC encounters** put people in the wilderness. They create conversations, trade, and complications that combat encounters cannot.
3. **Environmental hazards** drain resources without rolling initiative. They force the party to weigh competing costs: time vs. safety, speed vs. risk.
4. **Discoveries** are self-contained rewards for being in a specific place. They make the current hex worth having visited.

Any of these can be layered: connected to a keyed location elsewhere on the map, tying the encounter into factions or ongoing storylines. Layering is a technique you apply to entries from any category, not a category of its own. *Chapter 4* walks through the technique in detail.

The remaining forty percent is creatures or other potential conflicts, and those encounters hit harder because they're rare.

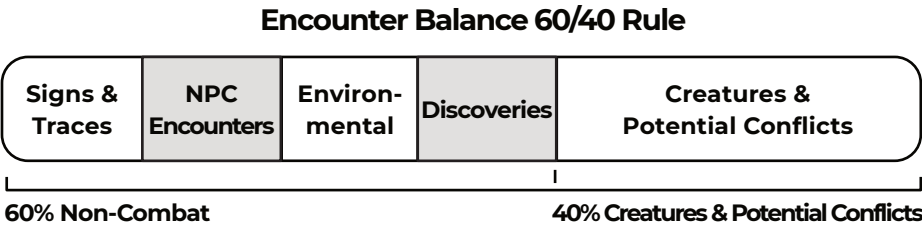
If you did the exercise from the previous section, you already know your ratio. If more than half your entries are generic creature encounters, replace the excess with entries from the four non-combat categories below.

Not everyone agrees on this ratio. Some GMs run all-combat tables and rely on keyed hexes for variety. I've tested both. Tables with a non-combat majority produce more player decisions per session and more memorable moments per campaign. The all-combat table turns the encounter roll into a damage tax.

Failure mode: An all-combat encounter table teaches players that the encounter roll means “roll for random fight.” A well-stocked table makes the encounter roll a moment of possibility, not dread.

Summary:

- *Stock at least 60% of encounter table entries with non-combat situations: signs, NPCs, hazards, and discoveries*
- *The exploration turn already drains resources through travel. Combat every watch creates attrition overload*
- *Audit your tables now and replace excess combat entries with situations that force decisions instead of damage rolls*



2. Signs and Traces

A sign is evidence that something is nearby without that something being present. Tracks in mud, claw marks on a tree trunk, a cold campfire with scattered belongings, blood on the rocks, discarded equipment half-buried in leaves. Signs create the encounter before the encounter happens.

Their value is not just atmospheric. A sign puts a choice in front of the party: follow the tracks or avoid them? Investigate the abandoned camp or press on? Following tracks might take a watch. Investigating a camp might mean making noise or burning daylight. Signs generate decisions from evidence alone, without requiring anything to fight or anyone to talk to.

Write signs as two-part entries on your encounter table. The first part is what the party sees: “Broken cart, one wheel missing, cargo scattered.” The second part is what it connects to: “Leads to a bandit camp in hex 0405” or “The owner is two hexes south, injured, willing to pay for an escort.” The sign itself takes thirty seconds to describe. The decision it creates can drive the rest of the session.

I recommend placing at least two sign entries on every encounter table. They’re the cheapest encounters to run and the most productive for player agency.

Failure mode: Signs without connections are decorative flavor text. If the tracks lead nowhere and the campfire means nothing, players learn to ignore all signs. Every sign must connect to something: a creature in the area, a keyed hex, a faction, or a situation the party can investigate.

Summary:

- *A sign is evidence of something nearby: tracks, old camps, markings, debris. It creates a choice without forcing a fight*
- *Write signs as two-part encounter entries: what the party sees, and what it connects to*
- *Signs without payoffs train players to ignore future signs. Every sign must connect to something: a creature, a hex, a faction, or a situation*

3. NPCs in the Wild

The wilderness is not empty of people. Merchants, refugees, surveyors, hermits, rival adventuring parties, pilgrims, smugglers. Every one of these is a Non-Player Character (NPC) encounter, and each creates a richer scene than another fight.

The key mechanic is a reaction roll. A 2d6 roll (hostile on 2, friendly on 12, most results in the cautious middle) prevents you from deciding every NPC's attitude in advance. The merchant who rolls a 4 is suspicious and will only trade at inflated prices. The same merchant rolling a 10 offers news about the road ahead and a fair deal. One roll, and the NPC becomes a person instead of a plot device.

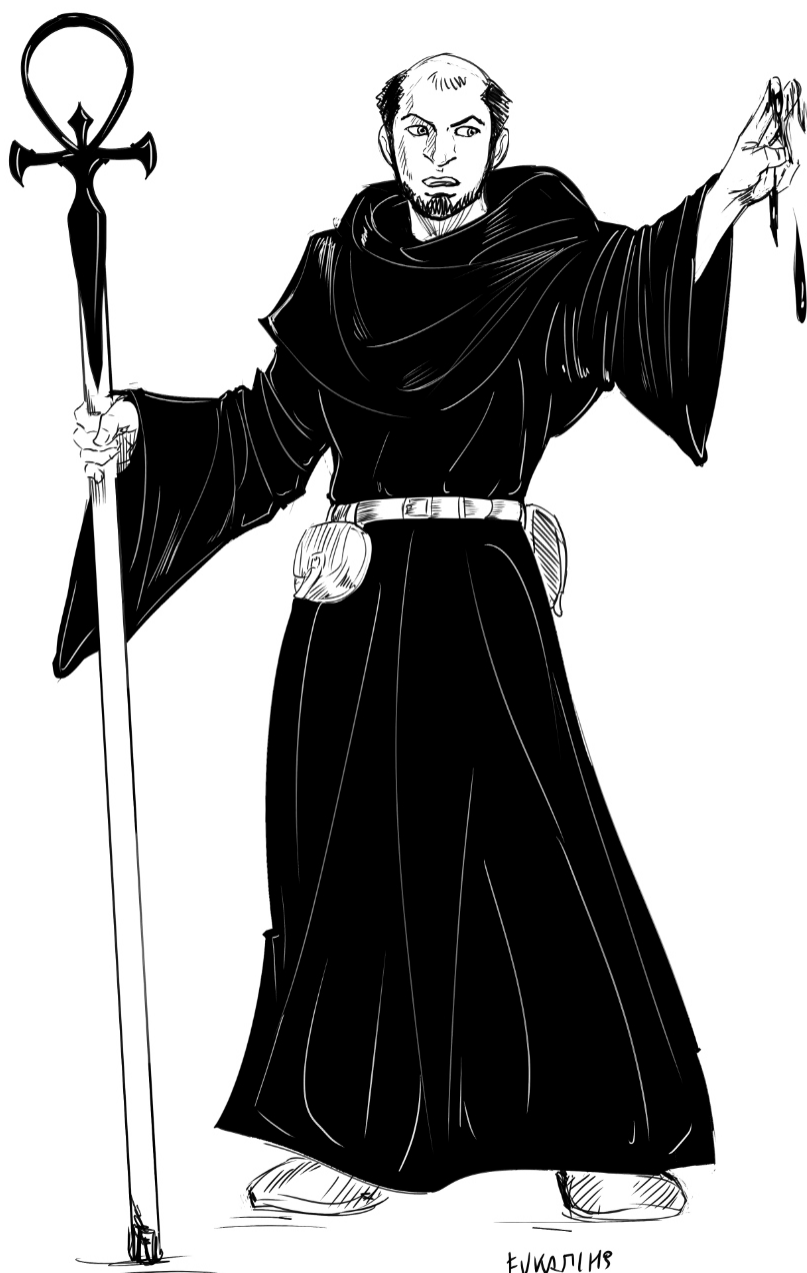
Give each wilderness NPC one hook: something they know, something they want, or something they carry. The refugee knows that the bridge at Thornwall is destroyed. The surveyor wants an escort through the next hex. The smuggler carries goods the party needs at a price they can argue about. One hook is enough to drive a scene. Here is a forest NPC entry that works: *"Charcoal burner (friendly), knows the woods. Will trade local information for tobacco. Has seen bandits to the northeast."* That is a two-sentence entry that creates a decision, reveals the world, and could lead anywhere.

Write two to three NPC encounter entries for every terrain table: one traveler (merchant, pilgrim, messenger), one local (hermit, trapper, shepherd), and optionally one complication (rival party, deserter, someone being hunted).

Failure mode: When every wilderness NPC defaults to "hostile bandit," players stop talking and start attacking. Reaction rolls and varied NPC types break this pattern.

Summary:

- *Stock your tables with merchants, refugees, rivals, hermits, and travelers, not only bandits*
- *Use a 2d6 reaction roll to determine NPC disposition at contact*
- *Give all NPCs a hook: something they know, want, or carry*

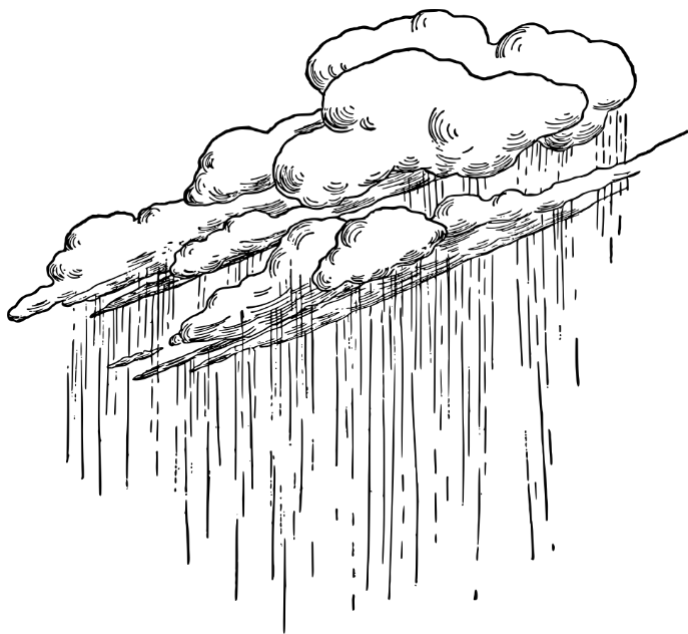


4. Environmental Hazards

The wilderness itself is an encounter. A flash flood turns a fordable river into a barrier. Dense fog cuts visibility to ten feet and forces a navigation check. A rockslide blocks the trail and demands a detour or a climb. None of these involve initiative rolls. All of them force decisions.

The key to a good environmental hazard is offering two options with different costs. The flash flood: lose half a day's rations swimming the gear across, or detour two hexes south to the bridge and lose a full day. The fog: press forward with a navigation check (risk getting lost) or camp and wait it out (burn rations, risk a night encounter). The rockslide: climb over it (risk injury, costs a watch) or go around (safe, costs two watches). Every hazard is a resource trade-off disguised as weather.

My advice: write environmental hazards that change over time. A light rain becomes a downpour becomes a flash flood across three watches. Each stage raises the cost of pressing forward. To pace escalation, borrow the reaction roll: each watch, roll 2d6. Low (2-5) means the hazard worsens by one stage. Mid (6-8) means it holds. High (9-12) means it begins to pass. This reuses a mechanic your players already understand and keeps you from deciding the weather yourself.



But escalation is not necessarily punishment. Sometimes the smart choice is to wait it out. The rain stops. The fog lifts. The river drops. Give hazards a natural resolution as well as a crisis point. The decision is real only when both options (push through or wait) have genuine costs. Pushing through risks injury and gear loss. Waiting costs time and rations. Ignoring the hazard entirely should sometimes be the right call, because that teaches players to read conditions instead of treating every hazard as a mandatory obstacle.

Environmental hazards also serve as pacing tools and work well as creeping threats (see Chapter 3). When you need tension without combat, drop one in. A storm watch between two quiet watches creates rhythm without rolling for creatures. The wilderness itself becomes the antagonist.

Failure mode: Environmental hazards that are just flavor text. *“It rains”* is not an encounter. *“It rains so hard the trail washes out and you must choose between a dangerous ford and a six-hour detour”* is an encounter. If it doesn’t force a choice, it’s description, not a hazard.

Summary:

- *Environmental hazards cost resources without requiring a fight: time, rations, gear, or health*
- *Always offer two options with different costs: push through or wait it out*
- *Hazards that escalate over multiple watches create tension. The party that acts early pays less than the party that hesitates, but sometimes waiting is the right call*

5. Discoveries

A discovery is a self-contained reward for being in a specific place. Signs point to something nearby. Hazards threaten. NPCs talk. A discovery just pays off. The hex itself yields something valuable: information, resources, a tactical advantage, or a piece of the world's history that the party now owns.

A vantage point that reveals terrain two hexes in every direction. A collapsed supply wagon with salvageable rope, iron spikes, and a water-damaged journal. An ancient boundary marker with carved directions to a spring. A sheltered cave perfect for a safe camp. Each of these rewards the party for choosing this route over another one. That's what makes discoveries essential to encounter tables: they're the reason players explore instead of beelining for the next known destination.

A discovery can also connect to something elsewhere on the map, but the connection is a bonus, not the point. The vantage point reveals a column of smoke to the northeast. The supply wagon's journal mentions a cache near a distinctive rock formation. The boundary marker's directions lead to a spring that's also a faction meeting point. These connections are valuable, but the discovery works even without them. The vantage point is useful on its own. The supplies are useful on their own. That self-contained value is what makes discoveries their own category.

Place at least one discovery entry on every encounter table. Discoveries are what make players say *"I'm glad we went this way."* Without them, exploration feels like a tax on reaching the next destination. With them, every hex crossed has a chance of yielding something the party didn't expect.

Write discoveries with specifics, not abstractions. Not *"you find useful supplies"* but *"three days of rations in a waxed canvas bag, still dry."* Not *"a good campsite"* but *"a rock overhang facing south, out of the wind, with a fire ring and dry wood stacked by a previous traveler."* Specifics make discoveries feel real and give the party concrete things to talk about.

Failure mode: Discoveries that are just treasure drops. *"You find 50gp"* is loot, not a discovery. A discovery should change what the party knows or what they can do. Gold is a reward. A map fragment is a discovery.

Summary:

- *Discoveries reward exploration directly: useful items, information, safe havens, or map knowledge*
- *The best discoveries combine immediate value with a connection to somewhere else on the map*
- *Write with specifics: “three days of rations in a waxed canvas bag” beats “you find supplies”*



6. The Layering Technique

Any encounter on your table, from any category, can be layered: given a connection to a keyed location or broader situation elsewhere on the map.

Layering is different from signs and traces. A sign is a category of encounter: evidence of something nearby, like bear tracks crossing the trail or a cold campfire with scattered belongings. Those signs create decisions on their own without pointing to a specific hex. Layering is a technique you apply to any category. A sign can be layered, but so can a creature, a hazard, or a discovery. A dead merchant on the trail is an encounter. A dead merchant carrying a torn map that marks a cache in hex 0307 is a layered encounter. The difference: the first is self-contained. The second is a thread that leads somewhere specific.

Build layered encounters backward. Start with the keyed location or situation you want the party to discover. Then write the surface encounter that points to it. The bandit camp in hex 0405 generates the broken cart, the trampled campsite, the survivor hiding in the woods. One keyed hex can feed three or four surface encounters across your tables.

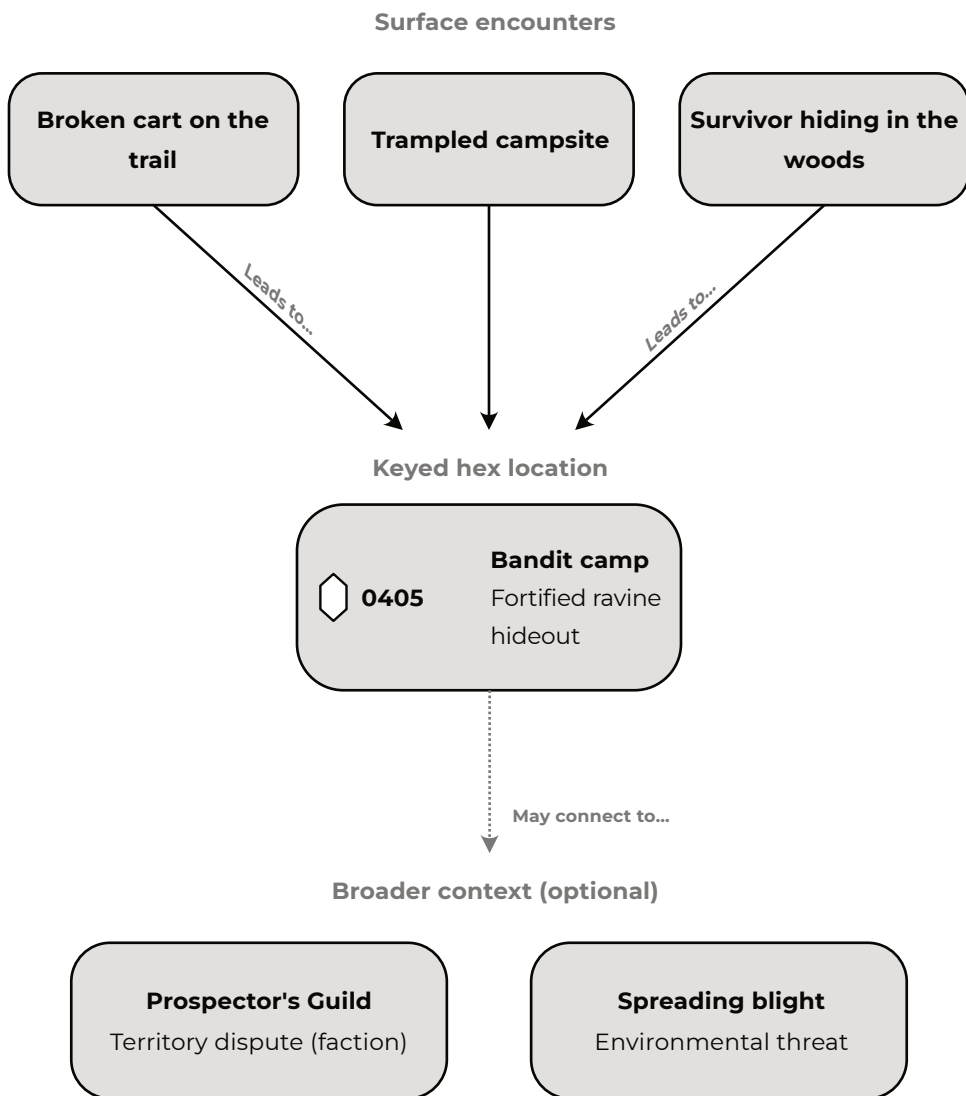
Tag layered encounters in your notes with the destination hex number. Write *“broken cart (leads to hex 0405)”* so you remember the connection mid-session. Without the tag, you’ll forget the link and the encounter becomes a standalone event. *Chapter 4* shows the full design process in a worked example.

Failure mode: Layering every encounter on the table. When every dead merchant, every broken cart, and every NPC carries a map to somewhere else, nothing feels incidental. I recommend layering two or three entries per table and leaving the rest standalone.

Summary:

- *Layering connects any encounter to a keyed location or situation elsewhere on the map*
- *Build layered encounters backward: start with the destination, then write the surface event that points to it*
- *Tag every layered entry with its destination hex so you remember the connection mid-session*

Layered Encounters: Surface to Source



*One keyed location generates multiple surface encounters.
Players follow any thread to reach the same source.*

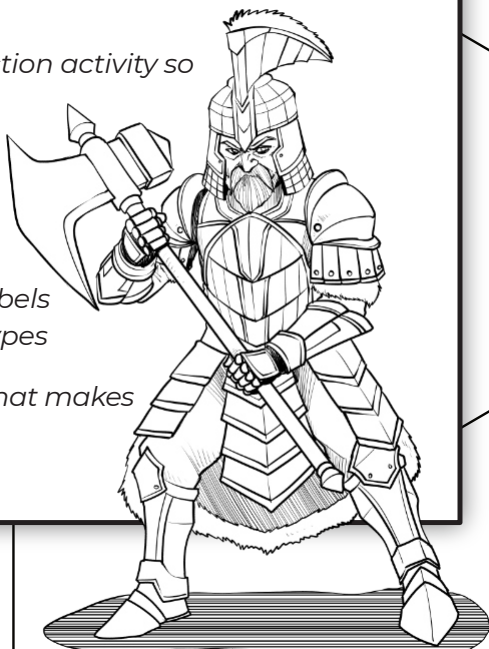
CHAPTER 2

BUILDING ENCOUNTER TABLES AND TERRAIN

Encounter tables do more work than any other tool in your hexcrawl, and I consider building them the most rewarding part of hexcrawl prep. In this chapter, I show you how to build tables that feel alive, match the terrain, and connect to the factions shaping your world.

You'll learn:

1. *The difference between a useful table entry and dead weight*
2. *How terrain shapes encounter content, and why one master table fails*
3. *How to wire your tables into faction activity so the world feels coherent*
4. *What to do when you don't have a table ready and need something now*
5. *How to break generic terrain labels into specific, memorable sub-types*
6. *A minimal sensory framework that makes every hex feel distinct*



1. Anatomy of a Good Table

A bad encounter table is a monster menu. “1: Wolves. 2: Bandits. 3: Owlbear.” That gives you a creature and nothing else. You still have to invent what it’s doing, why it’s here, and why this encounter is different from the last time wolves showed up. The table has done almost none of the work.

A good entry is a situation you can run in two sentences. What that looks like depends on the encounter category.

For creatures and NPCs, write three parts: who or what the players find, what it’s doing right now, and one complication or detail that makes the encounter specific. *“Wolves (4), feeding on a horse carcass near the road. Saddlebags intact, half-buried in mud.”* That’s runnable. You know the scene, you know what the players will notice, and you know there’s a decision embedded.

For signs and traces, write two parts: what the party sees, and what it connects to. *“Broken cart, one wheel missing, cargo scattered. Leads to a bandit camp in hex 0405.”* Signs don’t have an active agent, so the entry describes evidence and a direction.

For environmental hazards, write the threat and the choice it forces. *“Dense fog rolls in. Visibility drops to thirty feet. Press forward with a navigation check, or camp and wait it out.”* The hazard is the situation. The choice is the encounter.

For discoveries, write what’s here and what makes it useful. *“Spring-fed pool with carved stone steps. A bronze ring at the bottom, visible through clear water.”* Discoveries are static, so the entry describes the place and one detail that invites interaction.

The common thread: every entry, regardless of category, should be runnable in under ten seconds of reading. Two sentences is the ceiling. One is better. If you have to parse a paragraph at the table, the entry is too long.

I suggest formatting each table as a d8, one table per terrain type. Eight entries is, in my experience, enough to represent all four encounter categories with room for faction presence, and small enough to build in fifteen minutes.

Tables are living documents. When the players destroy a threat, cross out that entry and replace it with something that fills the vacuum. The bandits were keeping wolves from denning near the road. Now the wolves are back. Swap one or two entries when the season changes. You don't rebuild the whole table. You rotate entries, and the terrain feels different.

Failure mode: Entries that name a creature with no context. You end up improvising everything anyway, and the table becomes a random monster generator with no connection to the world.

Summary:

- *Creatures and NPCs: who or what, what it's doing, one complication*
- *Signs: what you see, what it connects to.*
- *Hazards: the threat and the choice.*
- *Discoveries: what's here, what makes it useful.*
- *Any entry can be layered by tagging it with a destination hex*
- *Every entry should be runnable in under ten seconds of reading. Two sentences maximum*
- *Tables are living documents: cross out cleared threats and replace them with what fills the vacuum*

Encounter Table Anatomy (d8)

Roll	Type	Description	Hex Link
1	Combat	Wolf pack stalking wounded prey. Aggressive if approached.	-
2	NPC	Traveling herbalist. Trades healing supplies for escort.	
3	Discovery	Collapsed shrine with intact offering bowl. Faction symbol.	0405
4*	Layered	Burned wagon with Guild ledger. Points to bandit camp.	0405
5	Environ.	Sudden fog. Navigation check or lose a watch of travel.	-
6	Signs	Claw marks on trees. Territorial patterns suggests large predator.	-
7*	Combat	Bandit scouts. Will parley if outnumbered, ambush if not.	0405
8	NPC	Prospector panning a stream. Knows shortcut, wants company.	-

d8 Roll

Category Tag

Situation + Decision

Hex Connection

Recommended Mix: 2 x Combat, 3 x Non-combat, 2 x Discovery, 1 x Environmental

* Faction-linked entry (connects to keyed hex)

Each entry: encounter + activity + hook. Copy this format for your own tables.

2. Worked Example: Forest Encounter Table

This is a temperate forest in the second week of a hexcrawl campaign. A bandit faction operates in the area. The canopy is dense, visibility is poor, and water is plentiful. I built this table in fifteen minutes using the category mix from *Chapter 1*: two creature/conflict, two NPC, one discovery, one environmental, two signs.

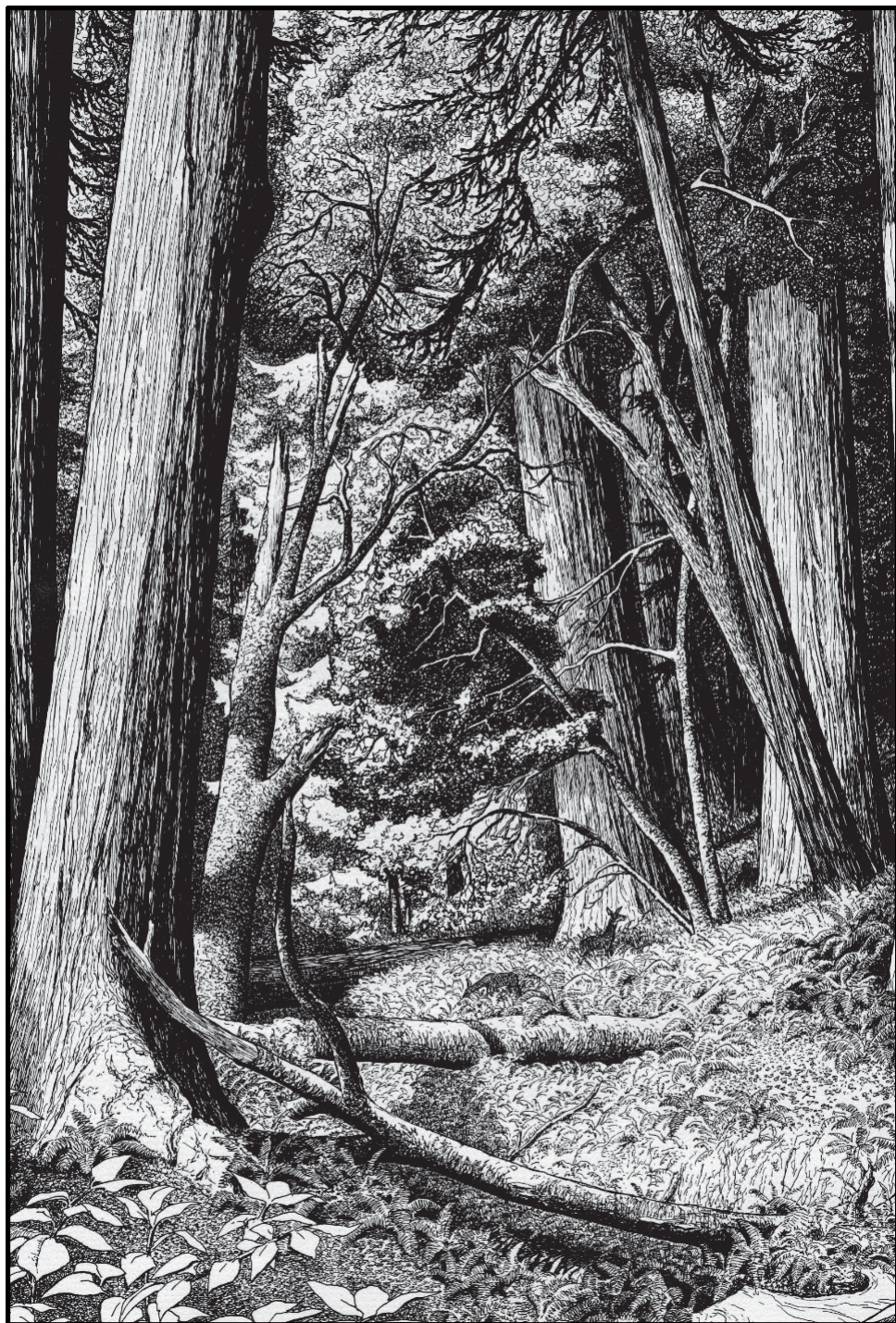
Once you've run this table for a few sessions, cross out entries the players have resolved and replace them with new ones (see Anatomy of a Good Table). Then build a second table for your next most common terrain using the same format. Notice how different terrain demands different entries: mountains give you long sightlines and vertical danger, swamps give you close encounters and footing hazards. Test your table: if you could relabel it from 'forest' to 'mountains' and every entry still works, the entries are too generic. A good table has entries that only make sense in that terrain.

Read the table top to bottom after writing it. If two entries feel like the same encounter, replace one. Every row should produce a different kind of scene.

Summary:

- *Two creature/conflict, two NPC, one discovery, one environmental, two signs: all four non-combat categories represented in eight entries*
- *Each entry follows its category format: creatures get activity and complication, discoveries get what's useful, hazards get the choice, signs get the connection*
- *Build one table per terrain, then cross out resolved entries and replace them as the campaign progresses*

d8	Category	Encounter
1	Creature / Conflict	Wolves (3-5) circling a wounded elk, focused on the kill. The elk is still alive and worth six days of rations if butchered, but approaching within 60 feet turns the pack hostile.
2	NPC	A charcoal burner tending a smoking earth mound, willing to trade local information for tobacco. He has seen the bandits and avoids their camp to the northeast.
3	Sign	A collapsed root cellar under a fallen oak, recently pried open. Fresh bootprints and scattered lamp oil jars. Leads to the bandit camp in hex 0405. This was one of their supply caches.
4	NPC	Two rival adventurers arguing over a hand-drawn map. They are heading for the same ruin the party's rumor points to. They will cooperate, compete, or fight depending on how the party handles this.
5	Environmental	Dense fog rolls in, visibility drops to 30 feet. Press forward with a navigation check (risk drifting off course) or camp early and burn half a day.
6	Creature/ Conflict	Bandit scouts (2) watching the trail from a tree platform. If spotted, one runs to warn the camp. If not, they track the party and report direction and numbers.
7	Discovery	A spring-fed pool with carved stone steps leading into the water. A bronze ring at the bottom is worth good money, but removing it muddies the only clean water source for a hex in every direction.
8	Sign	A forest shrine, recently tended: fresh wildflowers, a bowl of milk, braided grass. Someone maintains this place regularly. Connects to the charcoal burner (entry 2) or a hermit in a nearby hex.



3. Terrain-Specific Tables

One encounter table for your entire hexcrawl will break within two sessions. Forest hexes and mountain hexes produce different creatures, different travelers, different weather, and different problems. A merchant caravan makes sense on a road through grassland. It makes no sense above the treeline. When the same entries appear regardless of where the players are, terrain stops being useful.

Build one d8 table per terrain type that appears in your map. Most hexcrawls have four to six terrain types. That's four to six tables, each with eight entries. Thirty-two to forty-eight entries total. Most entries are one or two sentences, and terrain does the creative work for you: ask what lives in this terrain, what travels through it, and what has been left behind there. Swamps give you insects, rot, sunken ruins, and desperate travelers on bad paths. Mountains give you altitude hazards, predators with vertical advantage, and isolated communities that don't see outsiders.

Terrain shapes how encounters play out, not only what appears. A bandit ambush in dense forest is a close-range fight with poor visibility. The same bandits on open plains are visible a mile away, which changes the encounter from combat to a decision about approach, avoidance, or negotiation. Put terrain into the activity and the detail, not only the creature selection. Some GMs prefer one master table and reskin encounters on the fly. That works if you're a confident improviser, but I find terrain-specific tables do the creative work for you. The table itself reminds you what belongs here.

Start with your two most common terrain types. Write those tables first, playtest them for one session, then build the rest. You'll learn what density and tone works before committing to the full set.

Failure mode: One master table for all terrain. The same merchant caravan appears in the swamp, the mountains, and the forest. Terrain stops being useful, and players stop asking where they are.

Summary:

- *Build one d8 table per terrain type. Four to six tables covers most hexcrawls*
- *Terrain shapes encounters twice: what appears, and how it plays out*
- *Start with your two most common terrains, playtest, then build the rest*

4. Connecting Tables to Factions

The Hexcrawl Guidebook introduced factions as groups with a name, an agenda, and a key figure. This section shows how to put them into your encounter tables.

My key recommendation: write faction entries first when building any table, then fill remaining slots with wildlife, travelers, and terrain hazards. Faction entries carry the most narrative weight per line. An encounter table without faction presence is a nature documentary.

Things live in the wilderness, players bump into them, nothing connects. Faction entries change this. When random encounters reinforce the larger situation, players learn about the world through what they stumble across, not only through what you've keyed.

Here is what faction presence looks like. Take the Iron Tusk clan: an orc warband pushing into the hills, agenda: secure the ridgeline for a new stronghold. Their leader is Warchief Grukka, who offers bounties for scout reports. A d8 table for Iron Tusk-controlled hills might read: (1) Iron Tusk patrol checking a ridgeline, led by a scarred lieutenant demanding to know the party's business, (2) Supply train of goblin porters hauling timber south toward Grukka's stronghold, (3) Deserted farmstead, still smoking, Iron Tusk territorial markers on the fence, (4-8) wildlife, travelers, terrain hazards, discoveries. Three faction entries out of eight. The players never get an exposition speech about the Iron Tusk occupation. They assemble the picture from what they roll.

The ratio scales with control. Two to three faction entries in controlled territory. One in contested areas. Zero where the faction has no reach. That absence communicates something too. In contested territory, faction entries should show friction: a patrol that's nervous, a supply cart with extra guards, a burned watchtower being rebuilt. The entries themselves tell the players how secure the faction's grip is.

I recommend writing faction entries before filling in the remaining slots. Faction entries carry the most narrative weight per line, and they answer the question your players are actually asking: *"Who runs this place?"*

The Worldbuilding Guidebook covers faction design in full: territory mapping, faction traces as escalating evidence, and how to build factions that generate encounter table entries naturally.

Failure mode: Faction encounters that are all combat. If every orc entry is “*orc warband attacks*,” players learn nothing about the orcs except that they fight. Patrols, logistics, construction, and diplomatic envoys are all encounters.

Summary:

- *Two to three faction entries per d8 table in controlled territory. One in contested areas. Zero where the faction has no reach*
- *Vary faction entries: patrols, logistics, construction, diplomacy. Combat is one faction activity, not the only one*
- *Write faction entries first when building a table. They carry the most narrative weight per line*



5. The “I Don’t Have a Table” Fallback

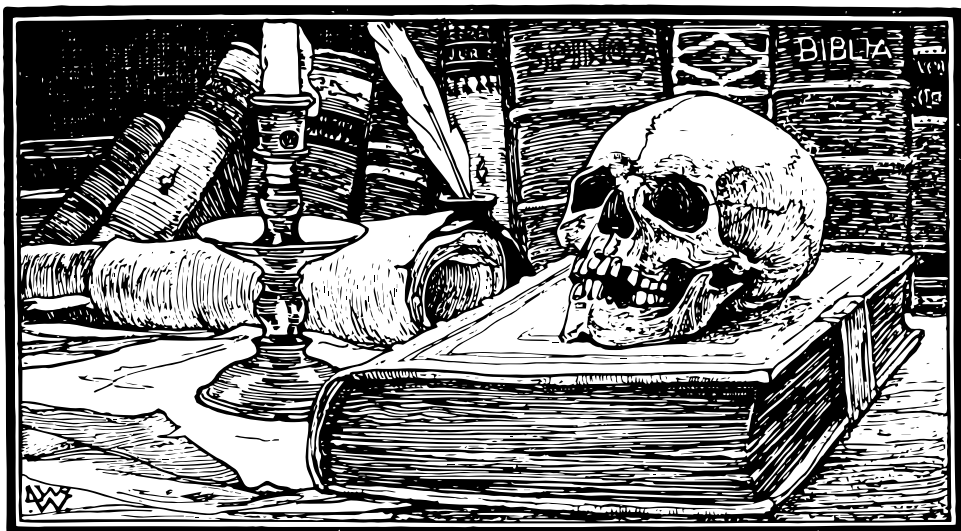
You will reach a hex you didn’t build a table for. Players never go where you expect. You need encounters anyway. Here are three techniques, in order of reliability.

Borrow from the nearest terrain. If the players enter an unprepped swamp hex and you have a forest table, use it. Swap the specific creature for something wetter. “*Boar rooting in undergrowth*” becomes “*giant frogs hunting at the waterline*.” The structure and activity carry over. The terrain detail is the only thing you change. This works because adjacent terrains share most of their encounter logic.

Use a universal d6 table. Keep this on an index card behind your screen.

Fallback Table (d6)

d6	Encounter
1	Animal (native to terrain) , doing something visible from a distance.
2	Travelers (d4), lost or in trouble. Need something the party can provide.
3	Old campsite. One useful item left behind. Signs of who was here.
4	Terrain hazard. Costs time, resources, or demands a choice about route.
5	Faction sign. Tracks, markers, graffiti, or a discarded item. No direct encounter.
6	Someone watching the party. They don’t engage unless approached.



Ask one question. “What lives here and what does it want right now?” Answer it, and you have an encounter. The answer doesn’t need to be a creature. Weather, terrain collapse, or a strange landmark all qualify. The question works because it forces you to think about the hex as a place with agency, not a blank tile the party passes through.

Keep the universal table printed and within arm’s reach. Improvisation is a skill, but a safety net removes the panic that makes improvisation worse.

Failure mode: Refusing to run an encounter because you don’t have the perfect table. Something is always better than nothing. A stumbling improvisation still gives players a decision and a detail. An unkeyed hex gives them nothing.

Summary:

- *Borrow from the nearest terrain table and swap one detail. Structure carries over*
- *Keep the universal d6 table printed behind your screen for zero-prep moments*
- *When all else fails, answer one question: “What lives here and what does it want right now?”*

6. Beyond Generic Terrain Types

“Forest” tells you nothing. It tells your players even less. When every wooded hex on your map plays the same way, you’ve wasted most of your map’s potential. The fix is simple: break each terrain label into three or four specific sub-types, then assign one per hex during prep.

A forest hex might be old-growth hardwood where visibility stretches 200 feet between massive trunks, or a birch thicket so dense that sightlines drop to 10 feet and horses can’t pass, or a burned section where charred stumps poke through waist-high fireweed. Each of these is “forest” on your map key, but each one changes play. In the old-growth, the party spots the wolves at distance and chooses whether to engage. In the birch thicket, the wolves are on top of them before anyone draws a weapon. Same encounter, same terrain label, completely different scene.

Do the same for mountains (loose rock slopes, alpine meadows, narrow ridge passes), swamps (tall grass marsh, flooded woodland, coastal mud-flat), and plains (tall-grass prairie, bare windswept flats, gentle rolling hills).

Write a terrain palette for your map before you key a single hex: list your terrain types down the left side of a page, then write three to four sub-types for each. When you key a hex, pick from the palette instead of defaulting to the generic label. This takes twenty minutes and pays off for the entire campaign.

You don’t need unique sub-types for all hexes. Repetition is fine. What counts is that “forest” never becomes the same experience across your map.

Failure mode: Every forest hex feels identical, players stop paying attention to terrain descriptions, and your map becomes a featureless grid they cross to reach the next dungeon.

Summary:

- *Create a terrain palette with a few sub-types per terrain before keying*
- *Each sub-type should imply different visibility, movement speed, or tactical conditions*
- *Reuse sub-types freely, but never let a single terrain label cover your entire map unchanged*
- *Palette showing branching sub-types for forest, hills, swamp, and plains*

7. Sensory Details That Stick

Sensory details are what you actually say out loud to make a hex feel like a place. You need one sound, one smell, and one visual per hex. Three concrete details, chosen well, will lodge in player memory longer than any block of read-aloud text.

Write these three details in your hex key as a sensory triplet. Here are three examples from the same map:

- **Hex 0504 (forest, serene).** See: shafts of light through old-growth canopy. Hear: a creek, distant birdsong. Smell: pine resin, warm earth.
- **Hex 0708 (swamp, oppressive).** See: black water between cypress knees, no horizon. Hear: insects, constant dripping. Smell: rot, sulfur.
- **Hex 1203 (hills, desolate).** See: bleached animal bones scattered across cracked mud. Hear: a low, constant wind that never gusts. Smell: dry sage and dust.

When players enter the hex, give them the visual first, then layer in sound and smell as they interact with the space. Players will remember “the bone flats” for months.

Choose sensory details that imply something about the hex’s history or danger level. A forest that smells like char tells players something burned here recently. A marsh where you hear frogs on one side but silence on the other tells players something is wrong in the quiet section. Details that carry information do double duty.

Resist the urge to add more. Four or five senses per hex dilutes all of them. Players can hold three vivid details. Give them three.

Failure mode: You write long descriptive paragraphs during prep, then summarize them into vague mush at the table because you can’t find the key details in your own notes.

Summary:

- *Key each hex with a sensory triplet: a visual, a sound, a smell, in a single line*
- *Choose details that imply history, danger, or change*
- *Deliver the visual first, then sound and smell as players engage*

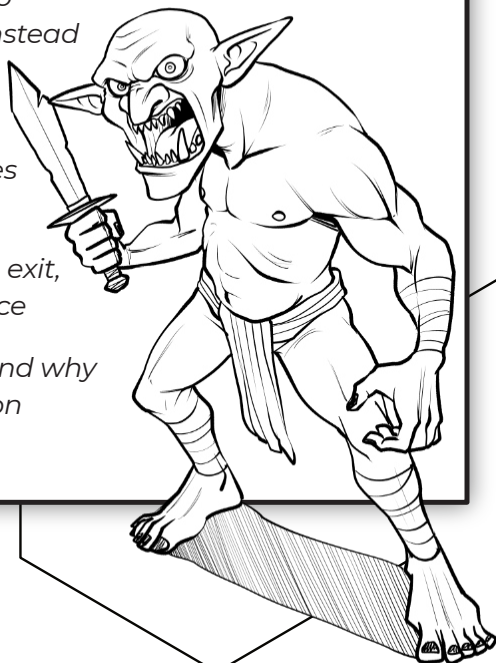
CHAPTER 3

ENCOUNTER PACING AND TENSION

A well-designed encounter means nothing if it lands at the wrong moment. I learned this the hard way: I once rolled a beautifully layered bandit ambush in the morning watch, right after two combat encounters the session before. The players were already drained and annoyed. They fought through it mechanically, missed every clue I'd embedded, and asked if we could skip to the destination. The encounter was good. The timing killed it. Pacing is the difference between a tense wilderness journey and a series of random interruptions. In this chapter, I show you when to fire and when to hold.

You'll learn:

1. *How to structure a travel day so encounters land with weight instead of becoming routine*
2. *Creeping threats: how to build tension across multiple watches without rolling initiative*
3. *Why every encounter needs an exit, and how to design for avoidance*
4. *How night changes the rules and why camps deserve special attention*



1. The Rhythm of a Travel Day

Each watch in the exploration turn covers direction, navigation, movement, encounters, and resources. A watch is six hours, four per day: morning, afternoon, evening, night. Night is camp by default. The standard trigger: roll a d6 per watch, encounter on a 1 (safe territory) or 1-2 (dangerous territory).

The pacing pattern that works best is: quiet, quiet, something. Two watches of uneventful travel, then the third delivers. But since encounters are random, you can't guarantee this by rolling watch by watch. I recommend rolling encounters for all four watches at the start of each day, then arranging the results for maximum effect. If two encounters trigger, separate them with quiet watches between. If none trigger, that day is a resource day: track rations, track water, let the players feel distance. An empty day is not a wasted day. You roll randomly, then sequence deliberately.

This works because contrast creates impact. A griffon circling overhead means more after two watches of empty plains than it does after the party already dealt with a flooded crossing and a suspicious camp. Compression is your tool for the quiet watches. A quiet watch gets one sentence: *"You push through scrub oak for hours, the sun brutal, your waterskins lighter."* Done. Move on. Save your descriptive energy for the watch that counts.

When an encounter does trigger, distance shapes what happens next. Open terrain means the party spots trouble far away: they choose to approach, avoid, or prepare. Dense terrain means stumbling into it at thirty feet. Fight, talk, or run, and choose fast. Terrain selection is encounter design: when the party cuts through the swamp instead of taking the road, they're choosing close encounters over far ones, whether they realize it or not.

The exception is hostile territory. Deep in a monster's domain or crossing contested borders, the pattern shifts. Hostile does not always mean busy. Sometimes the danger is in the silence: empty hexes where nothing moves, and the players know something should be here. When an encounter does trigger, it hits harder. The quiet watches build dread instead of boredom.

Failure mode: Every watch gets a full encounter, every day. The players stop caring. Encounters become a tax on travel rather than events worth remembering. When everything is dangerous, nothing is.

Summary:

- *Roll all four watches at day's start, then sequence for contrast. Quiet watches get one sentence*
- *Safe territory: quiet, quiet, something. Hostile territory: long silence, then real danger. The quiet builds dread*
- *Distance shapes encounters: open ground gives choices, dense cover forces reactions*



2. Creeping Threats

The best tension in a hexcrawl comes from problems that get worse across watches, not from monsters with high hit points.

Start with a sign. The party finds a half-eaten deer carcass, stripped clean and recent. Next watch, they find tracks paralleling their trail. The watch after that, something large moves through the brush just outside firelight. No attack. No stat block yet. Three watches of escalating dread built from description alone.

This technique works with any creeping threat: a problem that escalates across watches rather than arriving all at once. Rations dwindling as terrain gets harder. Weather shifting from overcast to rain to storm. A trail that was clear becoming overgrown, then vanishing entirely. The river rising watch by watch. Each of these creates a decision point without requiring initiative rolls. Surviving escalation is its own reward. The party that pushes through the storm finds the valley beyond it deserted. Everyone else turned back. The one that backtracks learns the terrain and avoids the danger next time. The party must choose: press forward or turn back, shelter and lose time or push through and risk exhaustion.

Keep a short list of creeping threats for each region: one predator, one weather pattern, one navigation hazard. When you need tension without combat, pick one and advance it by one stage each watch. Three stages is enough. Sign, pressure, crisis.

The crisis stage forces a decision, not necessarily a fight. The storm demands shelter or Constitution saves. The predator can be driven off with fire and noise. The lost trail means backtracking costs a full day. These resolutions feel earned because the players watched the problem develop and had chances to respond early.

Failure mode: Tension only comes from combat encounters. The wilderness feels like a series of arena fights connected by walking. Players learn to ignore any detail that does not have a stat block attached to it.

Summary:

- *Escalate in three stages across watches: sign, pressure, crisis.*
- *Keep a short list of creeping threats per region: one predator, one weather pattern, one navigation hazard*
- *The crisis stage demands a choice, but it doesn't have to be combat*

3. Retreat and Avoidance

If the party cannot choose to walk away, you have built a railroad with random encounters as set dressing. Retreat is not cowardice. It could be the most important tactical option in wilderness travel.

Design every encounter with an exit. The ogre is territorial but will not chase past the river. The bandits want goods, not a fight to the death. The wyvern is hunting elk, not adventurers, unless they get between it and its prey. When you place an encounter, determine what the party does to avoid it and what that costs them.

Cost is the key. Avoidance should be possible but not free. Retreating from the ogre means backtracking half a day. Avoiding the bandit checkpoint means cutting through trackless forest (close encounter territory). Giving the wyvern a wide berth costs an extra ration per person. The decision is never “encounter or skip.” It is “encounter or pay a different price.”

I recommend stating the exit explicitly during play. *“The creature hasn’t noticed you yet. You could circle south, but it would add four hours.”* This encourages players to think tactically about wilderness encounters instead of assuming every sighting is a mandatory fight. After a few sessions, they will start asking about avoidance options on their own.

Monsters that always chase, always fight, always find the party regardless of player action: these destroy the exploration game. Save unavoidable encounters for moments of genuine consequence. A dragon that has been hunting them specifically. An ambush they failed to detect. These hit harder precisely because avoidance was usually an option.

Failure mode: Encounters are mandatory. Players stop making terrain and route decisions because nothing they do changes what they face. The hexcrawl collapses into “move to next fight.”

Summary:

- *Every encounter needs an exit. Ask: what does avoidance cost the party in time, resources, or risk?*
- *State the exit explicitly: “You could circle south, but it adds four hours.” Encourage tactical thinking*
- *Save unavoidable encounters for moments that count. The fewer there are, the harder they hit*

4. After Dark

At night, the party loses every advantage it had during the day: visibility, mobility, full readiness. During the day, the party moves as a group with full awareness and all their resources available. At night, they are stationary, working with a thirty-foot circle of firelight surrounded by darkness.

The Hexcrawl Guidebook keeps night watches simple: each character pulls one guard shift, rotating through the night. For encounter design, the important thing is that whoever is on guard when something approaches is the only one who gets a chance to notice it. The rest of the party is asleep. A night encounter starts with most of the group prone and possibly surprised. That alone changes the stakes.

The campfire creates a genuine decision. It keeps predators at a distance, provides warmth, and allows cooking. It also marks the party's position for anyone nearby. In safe territory, a fire is comfort. In hostile territory, a fire is a beacon. Let the players choose and respect the consequences. A cold camp in monster country is smart play, even if it means a miserable night.

Not every encounter on your terrain table works at night. A soaring eagle or a merchant caravan don't make sense in the dark. Keep two or three night-specific entries in mind for each terrain: nocturnal predators, camp intruders, strange sounds or lights. You don't need a separate night table. Just skip results that don't fit and re-roll or pick a night-appropriate alternative.

Failure mode: Night encounters are just day encounters in the dark. You wake the whole party instantly and treat the campfire as scenery. The players never make meaningful choices about camp placement, fire, or guard rotation.

Summary:

- *Night encounters start with most of the party asleep. That alone changes the stakes*
- *The campfire is a choice: warmth and visibility vs. marking your position. Let the players decide*
- *Not every daytime encounter works at night. Skip or re-roll results that don't fit the dark*

CHAPTER 4

ENCOUNTERS FROM DESIGN TO TABLE

The previous chapters gave you categories, formats, and pacing tools. This chapter shows how three different encounters move from a line on a table to a scene at the table. For each one, I walk through the design decision, the table entry, and how it played out in practice. These are the kinds of encounters this book teaches you to build.

You'll learn:

1. *How a layered encounter is designed backward from a keyed hex and plays out as a discovery*
2. *How a creeping threat escalates across watches and forces a decision without combat*
3. *How a discovery rewards exploration and connects to the wider map*



1. Designing a Layered Encounter

The party is exploring forested hills. The bandit camp in hex 0405 is keyed: a fortified ravine hideout where the Iron Tusk clan stores stolen supplies. I want the party to find this camp through play, not through a rumor. So I build backward.

Design decision: I need surface encounters that point to hex 0405 without naming it. Evidence that something organized is operating in these hills. I write three entries for the forest encounter table:

- **Entry 3 (Layered):** *“A collapsed root cellar under a fallen oak, recently pried open. Fresh bootprints and scattered lamp oil jars. Leads to hex 0405.”*
- **Entry 8 (Sign):** *“A forest shrine, recently tended: fresh wildflowers, a bowl of milk, braided grass. Someone maintains this place regularly. Connects to the charcoal burner (entry 2) or a hermit in a nearby hex.”*

I tag both with hex 0405 in my notes. When either comes up, I know where the thread leads.

At the table: The party rolls entry 3 during the afternoon watch. I describe the root cellar: “Under a fallen oak, the ground has been dug out. Someone pried the cellar open recently. There are bootprints, and broken clay jars that still smell like lamp oil.” The party investigates. The ranger checks the bootprints: heavy boots, multiple sets, heading northeast. The rogue finds a scratched tally mark on a jar that matches marks they saw on a fence post two sessions ago.

No fight. No stat block. Ten minutes of play. The party now has a direction, a connection to a previous session, and a choice: follow the trail northeast or continue toward their original destination. This is where the mapper and chronicler earn their keep: one marks the hex, the other logs the clue. When the party returns three sessions later to raid the camp, it feels earned because they assembled the picture themselves.

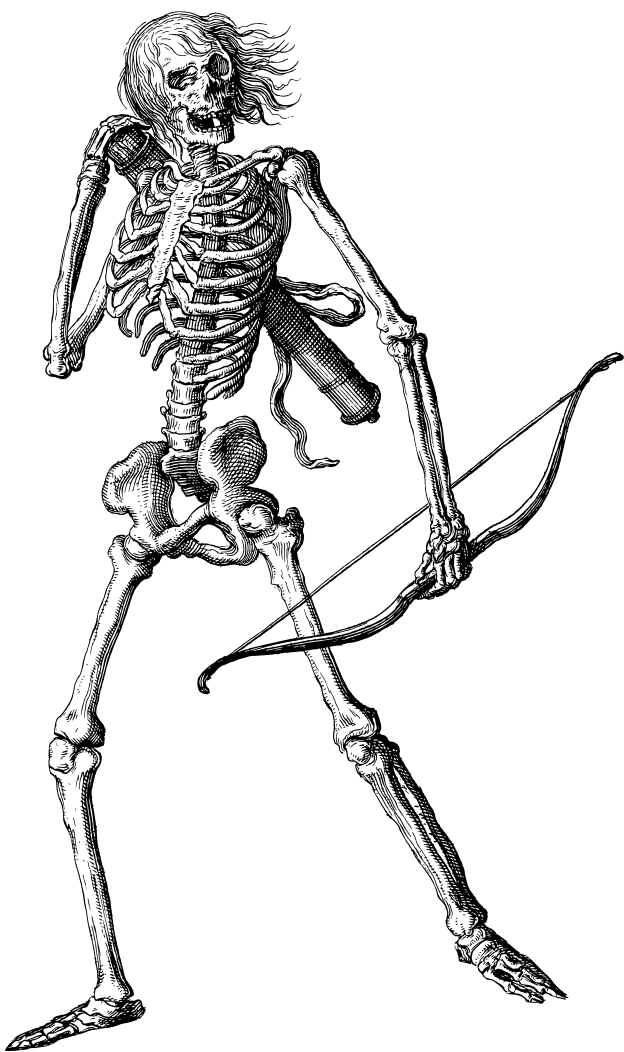
Summary:

- *Design layered encounters backward: start with the keyed hex, then write surface entries that point to it*
- *Tag every layered entry with the destination hex number*
- *The payoff is player-driven discovery.*

2. Running a Creeping Threat

Same campaign, different day. The party is crossing open hills toward a river crossing. I roll encounters for all four watches at the start of the day: one encounter triggers, on the evening watch. But I also want tension, so I layer a creeping threat across the day.

Design decision: I pick a weather creeping threat from my regional list: a storm building from the west. Three stages: sign, pressure, crisis. I could use the escalation roll (2d6) to pace it, but this time I know I want the storm to hit by evening, so I advance it manually.



At the table:

Morning Watch. No encounter. I describe the travel in one sentence, but add the sign: *"Clear sky, but a dark line of cloud sits on the western horizon. The wind is picking up."* The party notes it and moves on. Two minutes.

Afternoon Watch. No encounter. Pressure: *"The cloud bank has swallowed half the sky. The wind is steady now, cold, and the grass is flattening. You can smell rain."* The caller asks if

they should push for the crossing or find shelter. The quartermaster checks

rations: they can afford a delay, but barely. They push on. Two minutes, one decision.

Evening Watch. The encounter triggers: the crossing is flooded. Brown water, fast current, the crossing stones barely visible. This is the crisis combined with the encounter. I give them the choice from the Environmental Hazards format: *"You can wade across now. It'll cost gear checks for everyone and the mule might not make it. Or you can camp on this bank and wait for the water to drop, but that's a full day and you're exposed on open ground in a storm."* The party argues for five minutes and decides to cross. The mule panics. They lose a pack of rations but make it to the far bank. Fifteen minutes of play.

Night Watch. The storm breaks over them on the far side. Cold camp, no fire in the rain. I describe it in one sentence: *"You huddle under oil-skins on the far bank, wet and exhausted, but across."* The party feels like they survived something.

Total: the storm was never an encounter on the table. It was a creeping threat I layered over the day's rolls. The flooded crossing was the actual encounter, but the three watches of weather building made it land with twice the force.

Summary:

- *Pick a creeping threat from your regional list and advance it one stage per watch: sign, pressure, crisis*
- *The creeping threat is not on the encounter table. It's a pacing layer you add on top of the day's rolls*
- *The crisis stage should combine with or amplify whatever encounter the dice give you*

3. A Discovery That Connects

This last example shows something I like about discovery design: a quiet setup that connects sessions later. The party is exploring a swamp hex they've never visited. The encounter roll gives them entry 7 on the swamp table.

The table entry: “A stone platform, barely above the waterline, with carved channels that once directed water flow. An iron ring is set into the center stone.”

Design decision: When I wrote this entry, I wanted a discovery that rewards being in this specific hex. The platform is useful on its own: it's dry ground in a swamp, perfect for a safe camp. But I also added a connection: the carved channels match the canal architecture described in the Aulavarai ruins three hexes north. I didn't tag it as a layered encounter because the primary value is here, not elsewhere. The connection is a bonus.

At the table: I describe what they see: “Knee-deep in black water, you nearly walk past it. A stone platform, maybe ten feet across, sitting just above the waterline. The surface is carved with shallow channels, like someone was directing water flow. There's an iron ring set into the center.” The mapper asks if it's safe to camp on. Yes. The ranger examines the channels: “These look worked. Old. The pattern is deliberate.” I don't volunteer the connection to Aulavarai. If they've seen the ruins, they might make the connection themselves. If not, it's a detail that will click later.

The party camps on the platform. Safe, dry, memorable. Two sessions later, when they reach the Aulavarai ruins and see the same channel patterns, the mapper says “that's the same stonework from the swamp platform.” That moment of recognition is what discoveries are for.

Summary:

- *A discovery's primary value is self-contained: this hex was worth visiting*
- *Connections to other hexes are a bonus, not the point. Don't force them*
- *The best discoveries create moments of recognition sessions later, when players connect the dots themselves*

4. The Encounter Design Checklist

This is the page I wish I'd had pinned to my screen for years. One checklist for every encounter you design, drawn from everything in this book. Pin this page. Use it every time you write an encounter or build a table.

1. **Does it force a decision?** The party must choose: fight, flee, negotiate, investigate, ignore. If there's only one reasonable response, redesign the encounter.
2. **Does it reveal the world?** The encounter teaches something about the hex, the region, or the faction that controls this area. Even a predator encounter reveals ecology.
3. **Does it cost or reward something?** The encounter drains resources (time, rations, hit points, gear) or provides them (gold, information, a safe rest, a shortcut). If it does neither, the party will forget it happened. Resource pressure is what makes hexcrawl decisions count.
4. **Does it connect to something?** The encounter references a previous event, a keyed location, a faction, or a rumor. Isolated encounters are forgettable. Connected encounters build a world. Add a “points to” line to every table entry, even if it's just a single phrase.
5. **Does it have a way out?** Every encounter needs at least one exit that isn't “kill everything.” Retreat, negotiation, evasion, surrender. If the only resolution is combat, you've written a fight, not an encounter.
6. **Can I run it in ten seconds of reading?** Two sentences. The encounter, the activity or situation, one complication or detail. If you have to parse a paragraph at the table, the entry is too long. You should know the scene the moment you read it.
7. **Does it fit the hex?** Desert encounters in deserts. Swamp encounters in swamps. Faction encounters in faction territory. An encounter that could happen anywhere belongs nowhere. Check that it also works for the time of day: not every entry makes sense at night.
8. **Does it change if ignored?** The best encounters have consequences for inaction. The fire spreads. The refugees move on. The creature finds easier prey elsewhere and grows bolder. If nothing changes, nothing was at stake.
9. **Can I describe it in three sensory details?** One visual, one sound, one smell. If you can't picture the scene vividly enough to deliver a sensory triplet, the encounter is too abstract. Add one concrete detail and try again.

Glossary

60/40 rule. A guideline for encounter table composition: roughly sixty percent of entries should be non-combat (signs, NPCs, hazards, and discoveries) and forty percent creatures or other potential conflicts.

Creeping threat. A problem that escalates across multiple watches rather than arriving all at once. Three stages: sign, pressure, crisis. Predators stalking closer, weather worsening, trails vanishing. The crisis stage forces a decision but not necessarily a fight.

Discovery. A self-contained reward for being in a specific place. A vantage point, salvageable gear, a safe campsite, a piece of the world's history. A discovery's primary value is here, not pointing elsewhere.

Encounter table. A randomized list of possible encounters for a specific terrain type, formatted as a d8 table. Each entry follows the format for its category: creatures and NPCs get activity and complication, signs get what connects to what, hazards get the choice, discoveries get what's useful.

Encounter trifecta. The framework for evaluating wilderness encounters. Every encounter should do at least one of three things: (1) force a decision, (2) reveal something about the world, or (3) drain or reward resources.

Environmental hazard. A wilderness encounter that drains resources without rolling initiative. Floods, fog, rockslides, storms. The entry describes the threat and the choice it forces: two options with different costs.

Escalation roll. A 2d6 roll used to pace environmental hazards and creeping threats across watches. Low (2-5): the hazard worsens by one stage. Mid (6-8): it holds steady. High (9-12): it begins to pass. Borrows the same dice mechanic as the NPC reaction roll.

Exploration turn. The core hexcrawl procedure, run once per watch. Steps A through F: direction, navigation, movement, encounter check, keyed content, resources. Defined in the Hexcrawl Guidebook.

Faction entry. An encounter table entry tied to a specific faction. Faction entries show patrols, logistics, construction, diplomacy, or other organized activity. The ratio of faction to non-faction entries communicates how much control the faction has over the territory.

Fallback table. A universal d6 encounter table kept behind the GM screen for moments when no terrain-specific table exists. Entries are generic enough to work in any terrain with minor reskinning.

Forward pointer. A detail in one encounter that points players toward a specific hex or keyed location elsewhere on the map. Used in signs (pointing to something nearby) and layered encounters (pointing to deeper situations).

Keyed hex. A hex with prepared content: a location, feature, or situation. Keyed hexes are where the GM has written specific material. Unkeyed hexes have terrain and encounter tables but no written entry.

Layered encounter. A technique for connecting any encounter to a keyed location or broader situation elsewhere on the map. A dead merchant is an encounter. A dead merchant carrying a torn map that marks a cache in hex 0307 is a layered encounter. Layering connects random results to keyed locations, and sometimes to factions or ongoing storylines. See The Layering Technique (Chapter 1) and Designing a Layered Encounter (Chapter 4).

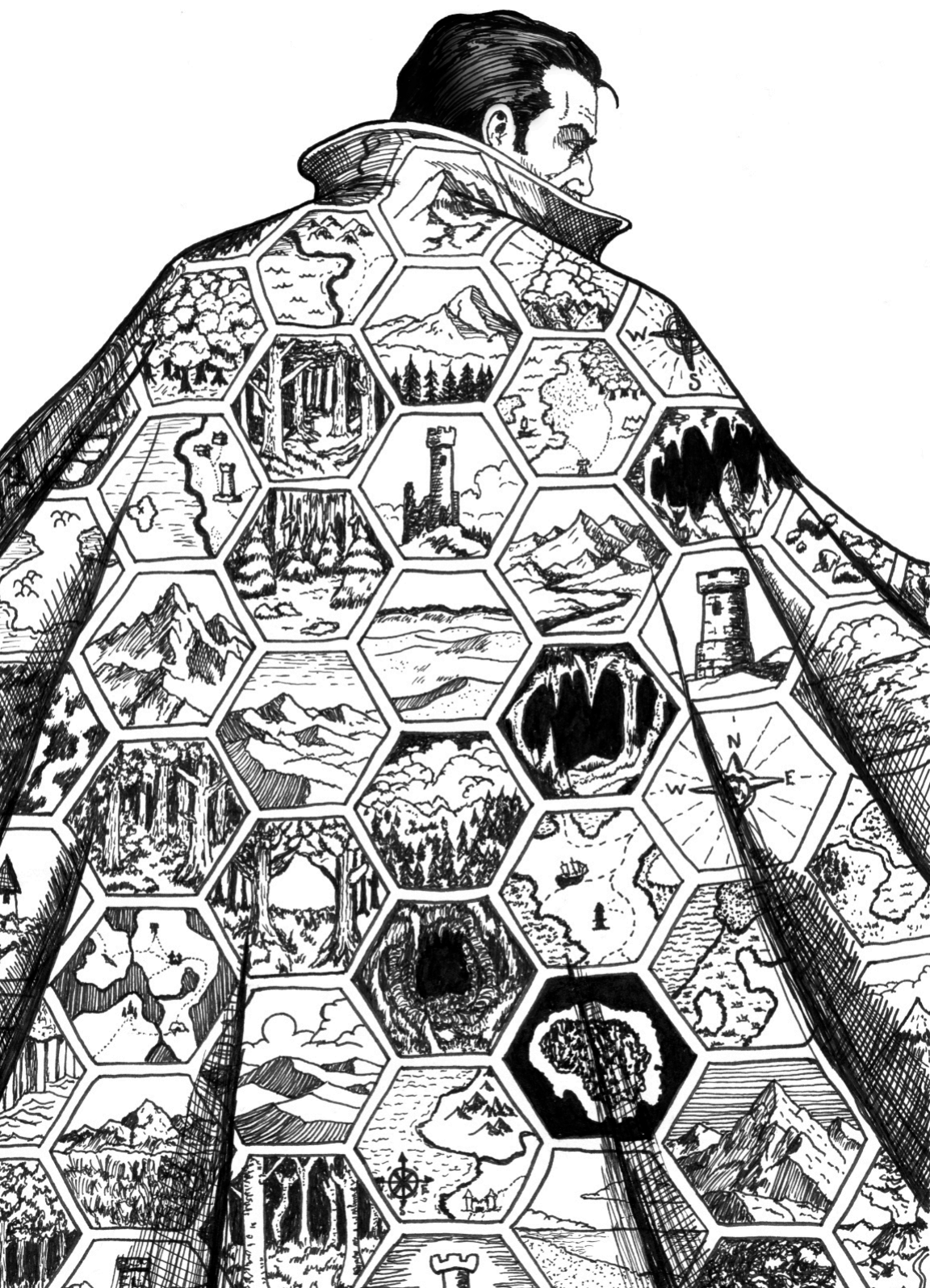
Reaction roll. A randomized check (typically 2d6) to determine how a creature or NPC responds to the party on first contact. Prevents every encounter from defaulting to combat.

Sensory triplet. Three sensory details for a hex or encounter: one visual, one sound, one smell. One strong detail is better than three generic ones, but the full triplet gives GMs enough material to describe the hex without improvising. Start with the visual. Add sound and smell when you have time during prep.

Sign. Evidence that something nearby is present without a direct encounter. Tracks, old camps, territorial markers, unusual silence. Signs create decisions from evidence alone and point to something local and immediate.

Terrain palette. A breakdown of generic terrain labels into specific sub-types. “Forest” becomes old-growth canopy, birch thicket, and burned section. Each sub-type implies different visibility, movement speed, hazards, and encounter tone. Three to four sub-types per terrain is enough.

Watch. A six-hour block of time in the exploration turn. Four watches make up one day: morning, afternoon, evening, and night. Each watch the GM checks for encounters, and the party chooses how to spend their time.





PRESENTS

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The Encounter That Felt Planned: A party crests a ridge and sees smoke rising from a village that wasn't burning two days ago. They realize the merchant they ignored three sessions back was carrying something important. Three random rolls produced something so perfect it felt planned.

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